

Under the Radar: How Predatory Policing Distorts the Reporting of Violence against Women*

Isabella C. Montini¹ and Jessie Trudeau^{†2}

¹University of California, Berkeley

²Syracuse University

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Abstract

A fundamental component of citizenship includes seeking protection from crime and violence. How do citizens make such claims to law enforcement when the police themselves are often predatory? The core argument is that police predation (1) discourages citizens from reporting crimes directly to the police while (2) shifting reporting towards intermediated channels. We argue that trust is the mechanism driving this reporting behavior. To test our theory, we focus on the reporting of violence against women (VAW) in Rio de Janeiro, Brazil. We build an original database of reports to the police and to an intermediary (an independent hotline), then conduct descriptive and causal tests to show that exposure to police violence redirects reporting from the police to the hotline. These findings bring together the claim-making and policing literatures to demonstrate that police violence incentivizes citizens to report VAW to alternative channels and, in their absence, to stay silent.

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[†]Corresponding author, jtrudeau@syr.edu.

1 Introduction

Protection from crime and violence is often described as a core component of democratic citizenship (González 2017; González and Mayka 2023; Lerman and Weaver 2014). Conventional wisdom suggests that, when seeking protection, citizens should call the police to report a crime or emergency. Yet few citizens believe the police will adequately protect them, and many believe that calling the police could cause additional harm. A resident of São Paulo, Brazil, told us:

The police came to the community and removed dozens of families from their home for a new construction project. They were violent and left many of my neighbors homeless. Am I expected to go to the same guys to report that my husband slapped me in the face?¹

Where the police are predatory, citizens seldom report crime and violence directly to them (Arias and Rodrigues 2006; Barnes 2025; Denyer Willis 2015). Yet for some crimes—including violence against women (VAW), the subject of this paper—obtaining a police report is an essential first step to access any downstream forms of justice, such as a restraining order. This paper brings the claim-making and policing literatures together to explain how citizens’ reporting behavior responds to police violence.

The core argument, summarized below, is that exposure to police violence (1) discourages direct reporting to the police *while* (2) encouraging indirect reporting to intermediaries that can make claims to the police for them. First, we argue that citizens use police violence as a heuristic for how they, or people “like them,” will be treated if they report a crime, building on literature in Latin America (Bruin et al. 2025; Cruz 2010; Urbina and Sgorlon 2024) and the United States (Owens and Ba 2021; Streeter 2019). As exposure to police violence increases, we expect citizens to be less likely to report a crime directly to the police.

Second, we argue that exposure to police violence redirects reporting through *in-*

1. Interview 1. All interviews translated and lightly edited for clarity. See Appendix E for the reporting and ethics of all the qualitative sources.

intermediary channels,² if they are available. Reporting crimes to intermediaries reduces or eliminates citizens’ direct contact with the police. Together, we claim that exposure to police violence reshapes the way citizens seek help from the state on matters related to safety.

We argue that this change in reporting behavior is largely driven by citizens’ lack of trust in the police. This mechanism is a departure from arguments in the policing literature, which demonstrate that certain increases in policing capacity can increase reporting to the police, and even increase the legitimacy of the police.³ Instead, we suggest that these very increases in policing capacity have limited promise where police violence is high and citizens are reluctant to trust a dangerous institution. Our findings add to a growing body of scholarship about the unintended obstacles to accessing justice when police fail to adequately protect the citizenry (Blair and Jassal 2022; Jassal 2020).

This paper focuses on the reporting of VAW to the police to test our argument. Underreporting of VAW is widespread, and survivors often remain silent (Palermo et al. 2014; Women 2024). Since the decision to report VAW to the police is particularly responsive to survivors’ beliefs about how they will be treated (Jassal and Barnhardt 2024; Murphy-Oikonen, McQueen, et al. 2022; Weitzman et al. 2024), we consider VAW a most-likely case (Gerring 2016) for testing our broader argument that anticipated police treatment can alter how citizens make claims to the police.

This study focuses on VAW reporting patterns in Rio de Janeiro, Brazil, a case with extreme variation in crime and violence, including but not limited to VAW and police violence. Estimating VAW reporting when the true incidence is unknown is a difficult measurement problem. To overcome this challenge, we combine detailed police records with records from an independent intermediary (*Disque Denúncia*) that facilitates public safety help for callers to their hotline. We obtained approximately

2. We define *intermediaries* as independent actors who can make demands to the state on a citizen’s behalf, and limit the focus to intermediaries who interact with the police.

3. For example, studies about women’s police stations highlight numerous positive effects due to increased policing capacity (Córdova and Kras 2020; Perova and Reynolds 2017; Sukhtankar et al. 2022; Sviatschi and Trako 2024).

30,000 VAW-related call logs from *Disque Denúncia* between 2013-2018, which we merge with police records of VAW and police killings. This allows us to compare VAW reporting to the state and to an intermediary for the same territorial unit and time period. To substantiate these quantitative insights, we draw on qualitative interview evidence and open-ended survey responses, collected over six months of fieldwork in Brazil.

We use two measurement strategies, beginning with two-way fixed effects models. We show that, at the police precinct level, police violence is associated with an absolute decrease in VAW reports to the police, an absolute increase in VAW reports to *Disque Denúncia*, and a relative increase in the the likelihood that citizens will report VAW to *Disque Denúncia* vis-à-vis the police. These empirical patterns support our theory that police violence shifts VAW reporting from the police to intermediated channels.

Second, we leverage the impact of an an exogenous shock—a reduction in *Disque Denúncia*’s operating hours—to estimate changes in VAW reporting. We find that approximately 242 VAW reports to *Disque Denúncia* went “missing” after they reduced their operating hours, yet fewer than half of these “missing” reports were then filed with the police. This suggest that most of the missing reports went permanently unreported. This effect was most pronounced in precincts with high police violence, where 63% of estimated VAW reports went permanently underreported. These findings suggest that when citizens are unable to put a safe distance between themselves and a violent police force, they prefer to stay quiet.

This paper makes four contributions. First, we explain how citizens make claims to an arm of the state that may be unsafe to interact with, building on González and Mayka’s (2023) concept of “asymmetric citizenship.” Existing work in the claim-making literature shows that citizens often rely on intermediaries when state institutions are nonresponsive, difficult to access, or poorly connected (Auerbach 2020; Auerbach and Thachil 2018; Cooperman 2024; Kruks-Wisner 2018a, 2018b, 2022). We build on this literature by identifying a different motive for intermediated claim-making: *safety*. In contrast, a vast literature demonstrates how predatory police forces

can harm citizens (Bates et al. 2002; Blair and Morse 2021; González 2020; Magaloni and Rodriguez 2020; Magaloni, Franco-Vivanco, et al. 2020; Magaloni, Robles, et al. 2020; Lerman and Weaver 2014), but few studies have shown how police violence affects the demand for citizen services. Our theory brings together the scholarship on claim-making with that on state predation, which have largely developed separately.

Second, this paper theorizes and measures an underexamined consequence of police violence. Our paper directly builds on studies that demonstrate how exposure to abusive policing erodes citizens’ trust in the state and reshapes patterns of political and civic engagement, both in Latin America (R. Blair et al. 2025; Cruz 2009; Flores-Macías and Zarkin 2022; González 2020; Magaloni, Franco-Vivanco, et al. 2020; Tiscornia 2019; Urbina and Sgorlon 2024) and in the United States (Ang and Tebes 2024; Owens and Ba 2021; Streeter 2019). By linking exposure to police violence to reporting patterns through the trust in police channel, our study highlights crime underreporting as another negative externality of exposure to police violence.

Third, this study contributes to our understanding of the barriers to accessing justice for survivors of VAW. Drawing from the “institutions as perpetrators” feminist logic in Lake and Hartman (2025), we show that police violence is an undertheorized barrier to VAW reporting. We argue that survivors need not experience police violence personally to be discouraged from reporting, and add police violence (in general) to the list of barriers that survivors face when reporting VAW, which includes feelings of shame or dependence on the perpetrator (Palermo et al. 2014; Wieberneit et al. 2024) and fears of mistreatment by frontline officers when filing a report (Córdova and Kras 2020; Blair and Jassal 2022; Jassal 2020; Weitzman et al. 2024).

Fourth, this paper represents a methodological innovation in our approach to analyzing the hard-to-measure concepts of VAW and VAW reporting. Some studies, primarily drawing from victimization surveys, emphasize that women in marginalized communities are less likely to report VAW to authorities (Bott et al. 2012; Palermo et al. 2014). Yet few studies have quantified these disparities or identified the conditions exacerbating underreporting to the police. We leverage rich event-level data across

multiple sources to estimate trends in reporting to the police vis-à-vis an intermediary to identify possible causes of these trends. This paper demonstrates how the use of multiple high-frequency sources of VAW reports can shed light on the “dark figure of crime” and what can drive reporting distortions.

2 Reporting to a Predatory Police Force

Citizens routinely make demands on the state, yet are often left disappointed by the result. These claim-making interactions are the subject of a rich and growing literature, which shows that such disappointing outcomes are more likely to occur when citizens’ claims lack political salience (Auerbach and Thachil 2018; Cooperman 2024; Zarazaga 2014) or when citizens lack the social connections to navigate bureaucratic channels (Auerbach and Kruks-Wisner 2020; Gallagher et al. 2024), among other reasons. Existing theories have largely focused on a particular kind of disappointing outcome: nonresponsiveness (Grossman and Slough 2022; Kruks-Wisner 2018a; Mettler and Soss 2004; Soss 1999). These studies show that state nonresponsiveness can discourage citizens from engaging directly with the state to resolve their problems.

Some problems are worse than a nonresponsive state. There is limited scholarship about how citizens navigate the decision to make claims to state institutions that might cause them harm. We add to the claim-making literature by highlighting a new reason why citizens opt out of making demands on the state: safety. We argue that predatory policing, defined below, discourages citizens from making direct claims to the police force. We further argue that it redirects citizens to make their claims toward alternative, intermediating channels, when available.⁴ We first explain the microfoundations of claim-making to a predatory arm of the state, and then generate three testable predictions.

Our theory begins by considering how citizen-state engagement changes when an arm of the state is predatory, specifically, the police force. Drawing on existing de-

4. Although our theory and empirical tests focus on a case where an intermediary is present, we also provide evidence of reporting patterns in the absence of an intermediary channel in Section 6.

pictions of predatory security sector institutions (Bates et al. 2002; Blair and Morse 2021; González 2020; Magaloni, Franco-Vivanco, et al. 2020), we define a *predatory police force* as one that uses violence, coercion, or abuse against the populations it is mandated to serve.

Just as the claim-making literature explains how state nonresponsiveness shapes citizen beliefs about future claims, we expect citizens to learn from their observations of police predation. Briefly, we expect citizens to use police predation in their community as a heuristic to determine whether or not it is safe to make their own claims to the police. We elaborate the logic of this heuristic in Section 7, which focuses on trust in the police as a mechanism linking police predation in one’s community and claim-making. We focus on police predation in one’s immediate environment—also detailed in Section 7—because it makes for a sharper heuristic when citizens are exposed to nearby victims “like themselves.”

When citizens observe police predation in their community, we expect that they interpret it as a signal from the state about how they will be treated from the police. When the police coerce, abuse, or use violence, it is also a signal to the citizen that the police are willing to do the same to them. This discourages future claim-making to the police.

This assertion is supported by existing research about police-community relations. In a study on “asymmetric citizenship,” González and Mayka (2023) show that, in participatory settings, police responsiveness to citizen claims varies depending on citizen “type.” The citizens deemed “security threats” are both more exposed to police violence and more likely to have not have their claims taken seriously. Other studies show that citizens consider police treatment of themselves (Brayne 2014; Lerman and Weaver 2014; Blair and Morse 2021) and of others (Desmond et al. 2016) when forming expectations about future treatment by the police. This assertion is also supported by convergent theories across the social sciences. Institutional theories, behavioral economics theories of risk aversion, and Bayesian updating theories all suggest that citizens will observe state violence and adjust their claim-making behavior accordingly.

If citizens opt out of direct claim-making to a predatory police force, two paths remain open. The first is not to make claims to the state at all, which includes strategies ranging from silence to seeking informal help. Cross-national evidence suggests that this is common. Citizens frequently stay silent or attempt to resolve safety problems through family, friend, or non-state neighborhood channels before calling the police, especially in contexts with high police predation (Arias and Rodrigues 2006; Bott et al. 2012; Palermo et al. 2014).

The second option is to route a claim through an intermediary (when available), which reduces or eliminates direct exposure to the police. We focus on intermediaries who can make or mediate claims to the police on behalf of a citizen. Most of these intermediaries in a comparative context are tiplines (e.g., *Crime Stoppers* in the United States and anti-hate-crime entities in the United Kingdom, such as *Stop Hate UK*). Some tiplines are not-for-profit while others are public, but all are organizationally distinct from the police. These tiplines insulate citizens from direct engagement with the police by receiving anonymous tips from citizens and passing them along, or serving as a chaperone or mediator for citizens when filing a police report.

There are two scope conditions about the intermediaries described in our theory. First, they must have an ostensive partnership with the police force, and be able to facilitate citizen claim-making to the police to some degree. This differentiates the intermediaries we study from informal organizations that provide social assistance but cannot seek justice on behalf of citizens (e.g., most religious or social welfare organizations), and from non-state authorities that citizens make claims to instead of to the state, such as the armed groups studied in Arias (2006, 2017) and Barnes (2025).⁵ Independent tiplines are the most geographically diffused intermediary of this kind. They are present in some form in more than 100 countries around the world.

Second, the intermediaries must be able to *insulate* citizens from direct contact with the police. While not all intermediaries will be able to eliminate contact with the police,

5. Given the presence of organized criminal groups in our case, we test for the possibility that citizens make public security claims to them in Section 5.2.

a core function of these types of intermediaries should be to limit contact between police and a citizen claimant. Hotlines that are directly controlled and operated by the police⁶ are not considered an intermediary because they are direct lines to the police force. Similarly, non-hotline organizations intended to facilitate police-citizen community relations⁷ are also our focus, because they require citizens to make claims while the police are in the room.

The form of insulated claim-making that we focus on is distinct from the strategies documented in the mediated claim-making and electoral brokerage literatures because of its emphasis on *safety*. Existing theories suggest that citizens make claims through brokers for efficiency reasons: intermediaries can leverage local knowledge and social connections to increase the likelihood that a demand receives a response from the state or that their elected representative is responsive (Auerbach and Thachil 2018, 2023; Cooperman 2024; Holland and Palmer-Rubin 2015; Nichter 2018). Yet when making claims to a predatory arm of the state, efficiency may not be among the citizens' top concerns. In fact, citizens may even be willing to tolerate inefficiencies or lower levels of service delivery (e.g., a slower resolution, a less certain outcome) if the intermediary increases the feeling of safety and shields them from a potentially lethal police force.

To generate testable predictions from our theory, we focus on police violence as a specific form of predation. It is among the clearest and most unambiguous instances of police predation. The state's monopoly on legitimate coercive force (Tilly 1985; North 1990) means that police violence constitutes a paradigmatic inversion of the citizen-state relationship: rather than delivering protection, officers inflict harm on the population they are mandated to serve. Police violence can also be measured with greater precision than less visible forms of predation.

We also focus on the most common and consequential form of citizen claim-making to law enforcement: filing a police report. We analyze violence against women (VAW) reporting because it is highly responsive to citizen perceptions of the state, including

6. E.g., 911 in the United States or the equivalent (190) in Brazil.

7. E.g., community public security councils and town halls studied in G. Blair et al. (2021) and González and Mayka (2023).

potential signals about how one will be treated upon filing a report (Córdova and Kras 2020; Jassal 2020; Jassal and Barnhardt 2024). VAW reporting is well-suited as a “most likely” outcome to test our theory (Gerring 2016) and detect whether police violence changes how citizens seek protection.

We illustrate our theory in two parts: first, how police violence discourages VAW reporting to the police, and second, how it redirects VAW reporting toward an intermediary tipline.

2.1 Police Violence Discourages VAW Reporting to the Police

First, we posit that when citizens observe the police harming their neighbors, it discourages them from reporting to the police. Recent work on police violence makes this link explicit. Exposure to police violence erodes citizens’ beliefs in the legitimacy of state institutions, which decreases their trust in and engagement with the state. Empirical research reinforces this at the individual level: exposure to aggressive policing is consistently associated with lowered confidence in the police (R. Blair et al. 2025; Bruin et al. 2025; Cruz 2010; Flores-Macías and Zarkin 2022; Owens and Ba 2021; Urbina and Sgorlon 2024).

In a recent report about mothers whose children were killed by the police in Brazil, one mother recounts her struggle to obtain a formal police report:

It is deeply painful. You see the indifference. You arrive at a police station, at the department, and the staff—I don’t know—they could not care less about you. They do not take you seriously; they simply do not care.⁸

Following this line of reasoning, we expect that exposure to police violence—and potentially its heartbreaking aftermath—will discourage the reporting of VAW to the police. Our qualitative evidence further illustrates this logic. When describing women who lived in areas with high exposure to police violence, a public prosecutor said,

8. Translated from the original Portuguese version in Asumpção et al. (2024, p. 71).

“These are women who are very afraid to call the police. They don’t want to go to the police station. And even the women who did go, who found the courage to take that first step, had a lot of complaints about the treatment they received there” (Interview 2). Formally, we hypothesize:

H_1 : Exposure to police violence decreases the likelihood of reporting VAW to the police.

It is important to note that H_1 does not require personal victimization by the police. Observing police violence against other members of the community is a sufficient deterrent from reporting VAW to the police.

2.2 Police Violence Redirects VAW Reporting to Intermediaries

Second, we expect high police violence to encourage VAW reporting to intermediaries that facilitate indirect contact with the police, such as tiplines. When presented with an alternative to the police, we expect citizens who are exposed to police violence to prefer reporting to these alternative channels rather than direct exposure to the police.

Why would survivors (or other concerned callers) not *always* prefer reporting to an intermediary instead of to the police force? Our qualitative evidence suggests that reporting to the police—even a predatory police force—can provide benefits that intermediaries, such as tiplines, cannot. In most legal contexts, filing a complaint with an intermediary may initiate the process that could lead to a police report, but is not a police report itself.⁹ A worker at a tipline in Rio de Janeiro corroborated this. She told us that their organization facilitates indirect contact with the police for callers, including forwarding emergency cases to the police for investigation and potential dispatch of police units. However, the tipline is unable to monitor the outcome of the process or provide further protection (Interview 3).

9. Police reports are often required for accessing downstream forms of legal protection for VAW. See Section 3.1 for more about this sequence in Brazil.

Though this form of intermediated claim-making may be an inefficient process, given the indirect route to obtain a police report, it may be preferred by citizens when the police are predatory. Were citizens to perceive the police as a more credible guarantor of protection, there would be no impetus to divert demands through intermediaries and sacrifice the legal standing that formal reporting provides. An employee at a women’s shelter said that survivors “prefer anonymous channels,” such as tiplines, to the police when reporting VAW (Interview 4). She added that survivors often perceive intermediary tiplines as a stronger guarantee of physical safety and confidentiality. This yields two related predictions:

H_2 : Exposure to police violence increases the likelihood of reporting VAW to intermediaries.

H_3 : Exposure to police violence increases the likelihood that VAW claims are diverted from the police to intermediaries.

The third hypothesis makes explicit that H_1 and H_2 are linked. As police violence discourages reporting to the police, it simultaneously incentivizes citizens to insulate themselves by claim-making through alternative, intermediating channels.

This form of intermediated claim-making thus comprises a single process in which citizens substitute indirect for direct demand-making to a predatory arm of the state. While the observable implications of this process can be measured by decreased citizen claims on the state (H_1) and increased citizen claims to an intermediary (H_2), the broader concept is inclusive of both trends (H_3). We test each hypothesis in the sections that follow, and return to the mechanisms underpinning them in Section 7.

3 Police-Citizen Relations in Rio de Janeiro

Rio de Janeiro is among the most violent policing environments in the world. The police were directly responsible for 1,800 deaths in 2019 alone, a rate of five people

killed by the police per day (News 2020). This lethality is not evenly distributed. It is concentrated in low-income areas with predominately Black and Brown residents, including *favelas*¹⁰ (informal settlements). In these areas, police are frequently in conflict with armed criminal groups and civilians are caught in the crossfire (International 2015; Magaloni, Franco-Vivanco, et al. 2020). Roughly 37% of favela residents, some 1.6 million people, report having been directly caught in the crossfire between police and criminal groups (FBSP 2023).

Violence against women is also pervasive. In 2022, Brazil recorded 1,410 femicides, averaging one woman murdered every six hours (Rogerio 2024). Intimate partners or ex-partners committed 82% of these killings, and 66% occurred in the home (FBSP 2023). The same women living under greater threat of police and criminal violence are *also* at greater risk of experiencing VAW.

3.1 Reporting VAW in Rio de Janeiro

After experiencing VAW, a survivor typically chooses between doing nothing, seeking informal help, or seeking formal help. A 2025 Brazilian report shows that the modal response after experiencing VAW is silence (47%), as survivors attempt to resolve the problem on their own (FBSP 2025). Seeking informal help is the next most common way forward, from family, friends or the church. Yet neither of these pathways, left alone, provides survivors with access to formal justice mechanisms.

The filing of a police report remains the necessary entry point for any type of formal protection, including those granted by the courts. A police report, *Registro de Ocorrência* (R.O.), is the formal document issued by the police when a crime is reported. Once filed, it can trigger further state-level investigative and protective procedures.

The R.O. is widely recognized as a prerequisite for accessing downstream legal

10. *Favelas* are densely populated informal settlements that house much of Rio de Janeiro’s urban poor (Holston 2008; Perlman 2010). A long line of scholarship documents how policing in these areas can perpetuate violence and illegality, rather than ensure security (Cano 2013; Misse 2009; Pereira and Ungar 2004; Trudeau 2022; Zaluar and Conceição 2007).

and social services. Public health agencies, the courts, and social services redirect survivors to the police to obtain a R.O. before assisting them, reinforcing the police as the gatekeepers of protection. For example, the *Lei Maria da Penha* (Law 11.340/2006), Brazil’s landmark legal framework, includes a range of protective measures to prevent and combat domestic and gender-based violence, but it must be triggered by the filing a R.O. These resources range from obtaining and enforcing restraining orders to investigative and prosecutorial aid for criminal or civil proceedings.

For survivors exposed to high levels of police violence, the importance of obtaining a police report poses a dilemma. The institution responsible for predation and violence in their community could guarantee their safety in the future.

A decade of victimization surveys in Brazil shows that survivors seldom report VAW to any type of formal authority (Bueno et al. 2017; Bueno et al. 2021; Bueno et al. 2023; FBSP 2025). When they seek help from authorities, they go to the police: 14% of survivors went to a women’s police station (see Section 7 for more details on these stations), and 10% to a general police station.

In an effort to increase the reporting of *many* types of crimes to the police, a crop of intermediary tiplines arose at the national, state, and local level, spanning at least 18 of the 26 Brazilian states and the Federal District (Disque Denúncia 2024). The main goal of these intermediaries is to facilitate safe reporting.

One such intermediary, *Disque Denúncia* (DD) of the State of Rio de Janeiro, is the focus of this paper. DD is a non-profit organization that works in close partnership with the police and other state agencies. Its primary mandate is to receive and process anonymous calls for help through a 24-hour hotline. When an individual calls DD to report a life-threatening emergency, DD passes key details about the incident (location, type of incident) to law enforcement while safeguarding the caller’s identity, after which the police often dispatch officers to the scene. If an officer is dispatched to the scene of an emergency mentioned to DD, and only if the survivor chooses to engage with law enforcement, a police report is filed.

Unlike emergency calls to the police, callers to DD stay anonymous when reporting a

crime or complaint. Many believe this anonymity emboldens people to come forward, both about VAW and other crimes. A DD employee stated that most calls to DD about VAW come from concerned family members or neighbors who heard or observed a violent incident. “Often, the survivor gets the courage to speak up only when the police arrive to the emergency situation, but are called to her house [anonymously] by someone else.” (Interview 5). This employee further stated that residents largely perceive reporting to DD as “safer” than reporting to the police given anonymity, even if it obfuscates the process of obtaining a police report.

4 Research Design

4.1 Outcomes: Reported Violence Against Women

The outcomes of interest are (i) registered reports of VAW to the police (R.O.s) and (ii) calls about VAW to *Disque Denúncia* (DD), the intermediary. Although the true incidence of VAW is unobserved, we leverage granular, high frequency data from these two sources to paint a clearer picture of VAW and VAW reporting. For all analyses, the unit of analysis is the police precinct-month level for the entire state of Rio de Janeiro, spanning from January 2013 to December 2018.¹¹ There are 138 precincts in the state, whose jurisdiction is determined by population.¹²

To test our first hypothesis, we consider VAW reported to the police as an outcome. We aggregate detailed event-level metadata from the police reports,¹³ obtained from the Institute of Public Safety (*Instituto de Segurança Pública*), to construct a measure of monthly physical VAW reported to each police precinct.¹⁴ We sum the reports

11. We begin our time series in January 2013 because of earlier data inconsistencies in police-reported police violence, described below in Section 4.2. We end our time series in December 2018 because *Disque Denúncia* changed their VAW record-keeping practices in 2019.

12. Precincts range in territorial extend depending on population density. Some are smaller than a neighborhood while others include an entire small municipality.

13. This metadata includes the day and time of the incident, the police precinct of registration, the victim’s gender, and if the crime is subject to protective legislation.

14. This variable sums reported VAW to a general police station and to the women’s police station in the precinct, if both are present. We explore differences by station type in Section 5.2.

Table 1: Summary Statistics

Statistic	Mean	St. Dev.	Min	Max	N
Outcomes					
VAW (Police)	15.32	16.37	0	146	9,638
VAW (DD)	3.03	6.64	0	98	9,638
VAW (Diff)	12.29	14.87	-36	134	9,638
Log Ratio	1.56	1.01	-1.79	4.48	9,638
Independent variables					
Police violence	0.23	0.50	0.00	6.67	9,638
Homicide	2.63	3.49	0.00	28.67	9,638

Note: Outcome variables are raw counts at the precinct-month level, except the Log Ratio, which measures the proportional split between channels and is not driven by precinct scale ($\log(Police + 1) - \log(DD + 1)$). Independent variables are three-month moving averages at the precinct-month level (current month and the two preceding).

of: (1) physical injury classified as domestic violence, (2) physical injury classified as protected by the national domestic violence law, and (3) femicide. There is substantial but imperfect overlap in the police records between all three categories, so we use these three filters to include a parsimonious list of relevant police-reported acts of VAW.

We test our second hypothesis using calls about VAW to DD as an outcome. We obtained event-level data, containing a summary of the call written by the call center worker, date and time metadata, and the call’s topic, according to DD’s classification system.¹⁵ We use DD’s pre-defined “Violence against Women” topic category as our main variable. We geolocate approximately 30,000 calls for the same time period and aggregate reports to the precinct-month level to match the structure of the police report data.

We construct a third outcome measure, VAW_{Diff} , to capture propensity to report to the police or to DD, and to test our third hypothesis about reporting being diverted from the police to intermediaries. VAW_{Diff} takes the difference between VAW_{Police} and VAW_{DD} for each precinct-month, and is positive when there are more reports to

15. DD does not use the police’s classification system because people often call about non-crime nuisances.

the police and negative when there are more reports to DD. On average, as shown in Table 1, there are nearly five times as many reports to the police than to DD, though this ranges substantially, from a minimum of -36 to a maximum of 134.

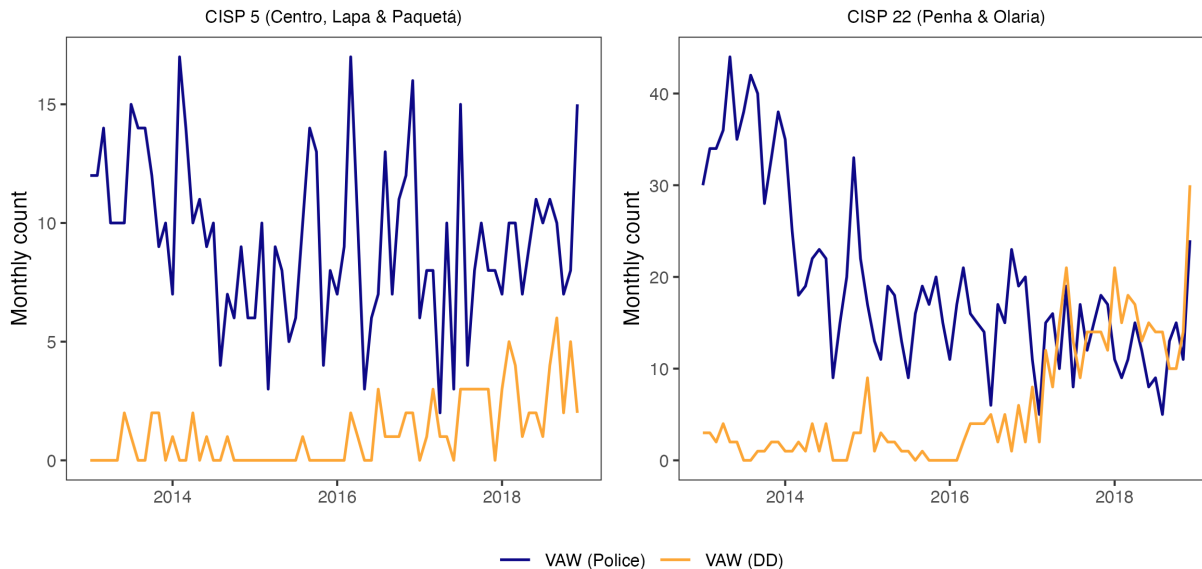
Last, we construct an alternative operationalization of the difference between reports to the police and to DD, using the log ratio of their difference. Unlike VAW_{Diff} , which is the simple difference between the first two outcomes, the log ratio is a separate test of relative likelihood to report to one or the other. A positive value indicates a higher likelihood to report to the police, while a negative value indicates a higher likelihood to report to DD. In Section 5.2, we consider other alternatives to this variable to operationalize the relative likelihood to report to one channel or the other.

That the mean of VAW_{Police} is greater than that of VAW_{DD} makes sense for two reasons. First, as noted in Section 3.1, victimization surveys demonstrate that reporting VAW to the police is the third most common way to report, after telling their family and friends, respectively (FBSP 2025).

Second, it is possible that some calls to DD lead to the filing of a police report for the same incident (and thus, an increase in VAW_{Police} for the same precinct-month), through the emergency response procedure outlined in the previous section. Unfortunately, neither the police report data nor the DD call logs reveal if a DD call ultimately led to a police report. Our interpretation, therefore, is that police-reported VAW *should* be greater than VAW reported to DD, given the possibility that DD calls could lead to a mechanical increase in calls to the police if a police report is filed. When VAW_{Diff} takes on a negative value, and VAW reports to DD exceed those to the police, we interpret this as strong signal that citizens do not want to report to the police.

We illustrate this variation in Figure 1, which shows VAW reporting in two sample precincts. We provide detailed vignettes about these precincts in Appendix A.1, but briefly, the figure on the left represents a precinct the police are the primary law enforcement authority. In the precinct on the right, there is deep mistrust in the police. Events in 2017 increased the salience of this mistrust, and calls to DD overtook reports to the police. Both figures demonstrate that police-reported VAW should thus

Figure 1: Monthly VAW Reports to the Police and *Disque Denúncia* in Two Police Precincts



be thought of as a variable representing the *limits* of what law enforcement knows about the distribution of VAW, rather than its true prevalence.

4.2 Independent Variable: Exposure to Police Violence

Our main independent variable captures exposure to police violence. Although police killings underestimate the true level of police violence, it is the most reliable indicator of police violence available, and hence our preferred proxy. This study begins in January 2013 because this is when killings by the police began being systematically reported.¹⁶

To operationalize exposure to police violence, we calculate a 3-month moving average of police-reported police killings for each precinct. Despite the soaring levels of police violence in Rio de Janeiro during the study period (International 2015), an individual precinct is such a small territorial unit of analysis that a police killing remains a relatively rare event, and killings are concentrated in select areas. Smoothing over the preceding months therefore provides a less noisy measure of neighborhood-level exposure to police violence and reduces sensitivity to short-term shocks, though we

16. The national *Council for the Defense of Human Rights* standardized the reporting of police killings in a top-down reform (08/2012) in December 2012.

test several alternative variables in the robustness checks.

Though not the main theoretical focus of this paper, we also consider the possibility that societal or criminal violence could confound the relationship between VAW and police violence. We measure exposure to societal violence by focusing on its most visible form, police-reported homicides. Police killings indeed are concentrated in the most homicidal precincts (Figure A1) and more common than police killings (Table 1). We control for the 3-month moving average in our main specifications to separate it from the effect of police violence on reported VAW.

4.3 Empirical Specification

We estimate the relationship between exposure to police violence and VAW reporting within precincts over time, controlling for time-varying violence levels and precinct fixed-effects to eliminate time-invariant confounders. These two-way fixed effects (TWFE) models take the following baseline form, where i and t correspond to the police precinct and month:

$$VAW_{it} = \beta_1 Police_Violence_{it} + \rho_i + \gamma_t + \epsilon_{it} \quad (1)$$

VAW_{it} corresponds to one of four outcomes: reported VAW to the police, to DD, their difference, or the log ratio. β_1 is the coefficient of interest, representing the relationship between the moving average for police killings in a particular precinct and reported VAW incidents. We include police-precinct (ρ_i) and monthly (γ_t) fixed effects. Robust standard errors are clustered at the precinct-level.

By including precinct-level fixed effects, this specification estimates the relationship between exposure to police violence and reported VAW based only on variation within the precinct. This addresses endogeneity concerns by controlling for unobserved, time-invariant differences in precinct demographics, urbanization, informality, and socioeconomic status. We include the fixed effect γ_t to account for potential temporal changes,

Table 2: Police Violence and VAW Reporting

	VAW (Police)		VAW (DD)		VAW (Diff)		Log Ratio	
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)	(7)	(8)
Police Violence	-1.411*** (0.353)	-1.403*** (0.341)	1.970*** (0.539)	2.006*** (0.549)	-3.381*** (0.747)	-3.410*** (0.755)	-0.209*** (0.035)	-0.202*** (0.034)
Homicide		-0.027 (0.157)		-0.133 (0.131)		0.107 (0.229)		-0.024** (0.009)
Observations	9,638	9,638	9,638	9,638	9,638	9,638	9,638	9,638
DV Mean	15.319	15.319	3.030	3.030	12.289	12.289	1.555	1.555
R2	0.886	0.886	0.570	0.570	0.737	0.738	0.608	0.609
R2 Adj.	0.883	0.883	0.560	0.561	0.732	0.732	0.599	0.600
Precinct FE	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Month-Year FE	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓

Note: Standard errors are clustered at the precinct-level: 138 clusters. * $p < 0.1$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$

including the seasonality of crime, and idiosyncratic changes in policing patterns. We also estimate models controlling for exposure to societal violence ($Homicide_{it}$), which could be a potentially problematic time-varying confounder. Unless otherwise noted, all models use the three-month moving average for both the police violence and homicide variables.

The TWFE approach reduces omitted variable bias by accounting for factors that might be correlated with both the independent and the dependent variables, but it is not without flaws. We estimate alternative models that address some of the challenges to inference inherent in TWFE models, discussed in greater detail in Section 5.2.

5 VAW Reporting and Police Violence

The main results in Table 2 provide strong supporting evidence that police violence redirects VAW calls from the police to DD. The odd-numbered models show the baseline model (Equation 1) and the even-numbered models control for homicides to separate the effect of police killings from that of societal violence.

Models 1 and 2 show that police violence is negatively and significantly associated with VAW reporting to the police. Precincts experiencing more police killings see fewer VAW reports filed with the police, even when controlling for higher levels of societal violence. A one-standard-deviation increase in the residualized *Police Violence* variable ($SD = 0.344$) corresponds to a decline of approximately 0.482 VAW reports to the police per precinct-month, a 3.1 percentage point decrease relative to the mean.¹⁷

In contrast, Models 3 and 4 show that police violence is positively associated with VAW reports to DD. The coefficient of interest is nearly identical in magnitude and statistical significance after controlling for homicides, suggesting that increases in societal violence do little to explain increased reporting to intermediary channels. A one-standard-deviation increase in the residualized *Police Violence* variable corresponds to a considerable increase in DD reports per precinct-month (0.689), a 23.2 percentage point increase over the mean.

Models 5-8 support our theory that these changes in reporting are happening in tandem. Precincts where police violence is high experience a significant decline in levels of reported VAW to the police vis-à-vis to DD. Since the outcome variable VAW_{Diff} takes on a positive (negative) value when there are more (less) reports to the police relative to DD, we interpret the large, negative coefficient as supporting evidence that individuals direct reports of VAW *away* from the police and towards DD when police violence is high. A one-standard-deviation increase in the residualized *Police Violence* variable corresponds to an approximate displacement of 1.172 VAW reports from the police to DD per precinct-month, a 9.4 percentage point shift relative to the mean difference in reporting between the two. Though interpretation is less straightforward than the simple difference, Models 7-8 confirm that there is a large, statistically significant decline in relative call volume to the police vis-à-vis DD when operationalized as the log ratio.

Together, these findings provide direct support for our hypotheses. When exposed

17. We residualize the treatment with respect to unit and time fixed effects before calculating its standard deviation to provide a plausible counterfactual increase in the treatment variable, as in Mummolo and Peterson (2018).

to police violence, we document statistically significant absolute decreases (increases) in reports to the police (to DD). On average, citizens are more likely to call the police to report VAW, but as police violence increases, citizens shift VAW reporting away from police authorities and toward DD. Even if some DD calls are subsequently logged as police reports, the possibility that some calls are passed from DD to the police does not explain the relative shift in reports towards DD vis-à-vis the police in Models 5-8.

5.1 VAW Reporting amid Police and Societal Violence

We consider the possibility that societal violence may plausibly drive *both* police use of force and reshape VAW reporting patterns. The extant literature shows that violence and insecurity enable VAW (Cohen 2016; Hernández Gress et al. 2023; Hume 2004; Massa Roldan et al. 2021; Wood 2014; Weitzman et al. 2024; UNODC 2023). This section further probes the relationship between VAW reporting and societal violence.

In Table 3, we re-estimate Equation 1, interacting police violence with an indicator for societal violence, whose calculation is detailed in the table notes. The predicted VAW reporting patterns are most acute under compound exposure to police and societal violence. For all models, the interaction terms are statistically significant and larger in magnitude than the baseline models.

The shift in relative reporting (Models 3-4) is large compared to the main findings, both when operationalized as the simple difference and the log ratio. A one-standard-deviation increase in the residualized interaction term (Model 3, $SD = 0.334$) corresponds to a 10.8 percentage point shift in report volume towards DD, depicted graphically in Figure 2. Where societal violence is low, increases in police violence do not meaningfully shift reporting. Where societal violence is high, however, the same increases in police violence are associated with a substantial shift in reporting away from the police and toward DD. At approximately 2.3 police killings per precinct-month, it is more likely that DD will receive more VAW reports than the police.

Two takeaways follow. First, exposure to societal violence amplifies the effects predicted by our theory. Second, our results add nuance to existing theories of VAW and

Table 3: Police Violence, Societal Violence, and VAW Reporting, Interactive Models

	VAW (Police)	VAW (DD)	VAW (Diff)	Log Ratio
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)
Police Violence $\times$ Homicide	-1.451*** (0.505)	2.596*** (0.609)	-4.047*** (0.865)	-0.151** (0.061)
Police Violence	-0.114 (0.429)	-0.346 (0.441)	0.232 (0.622)	-0.073 (0.060)
Homicide	0.247 (0.272)	-1.031*** (0.333)	1.278*** (0.416)	-0.012 (0.034)
Num.Obs.	9638	9638	9638	9638
DV Mean	15.319	3.030	12.289	1.555
R2	0.886	0.572	0.739	0.608
R2 Adj.	0.883	0.563	0.733	0.600
Precinct FE	✓	✓	✓	✓
Month-Year FE	✓	✓	✓	✓

Note: Homicide is a binary indicator for precinct-months whose three-month moving average of homicides falls above the sample median. Standard errors are clustered at the precinct-level: 138 clusters. * $p < 0.1$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$

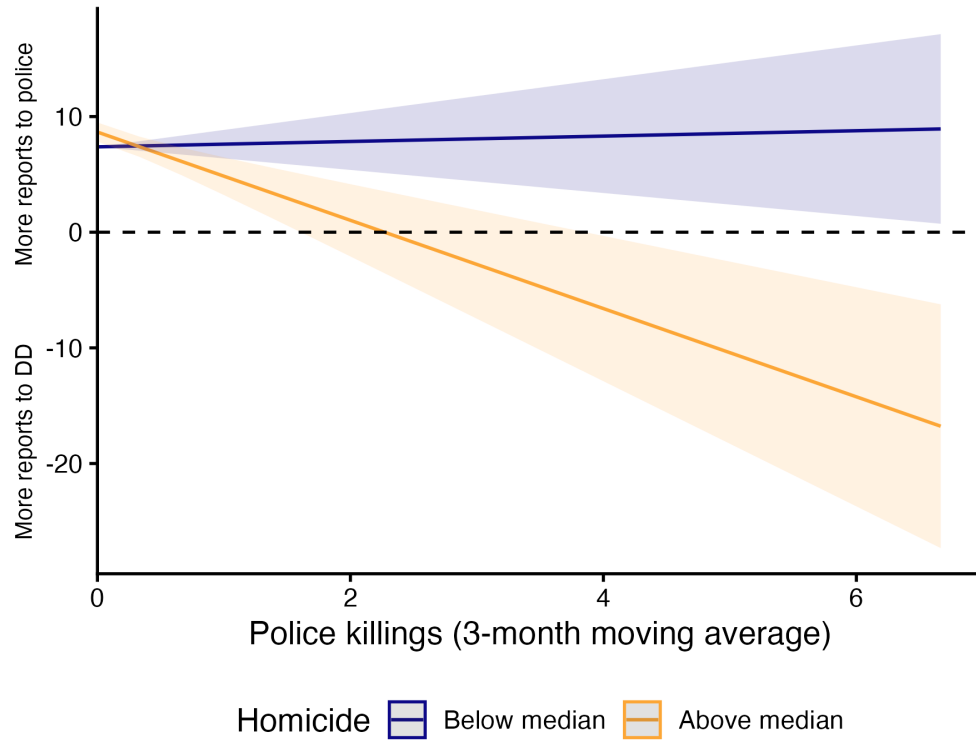
conflict, which predict a rise in VAW alongside rising societal violence. We demonstrate that higher levels of violence can reshape VAW reporting, potentially obstructing the relationship between violent conflict and unobserved VAW.

5.2 Robustness

We conduct several checks to probe the robustness of the main findings. We begin with sensitivity tests of the independent variables to mitigate concerns that the police killing variable is misspecified.

to mitigate various concerns about contemporaneous shocks, responsiveness to or awareness of police killings, or post-treatment bias, we estimate Equation 1 using the contemporaneous count for police violence and homicide rather than a moving average (Table C1), a one-period lag of police violence and homicide (Table C2), and

Figure 2: Predicted Shift in VAW Reporting Across Channels



Note: This is a visual representation of the marginal effects of the interaction term in Model 3, Table 3.

a one-period lagged homicide control (Table C3). We also use a one-period lag of police violence with a homicide control lagged by two periods (Table C4) to address the possibility that police violence responds to local violence. All results mirror the magnitude and significance of the main findings.

We further test the sensitivity of the police killings variable in two ways. First, we construct a “massacre” variable measuring police killings where two or more individuals were killed in the same precinct-day. As expected, Models 1-3 of Table C5 show that these events shift reporting between channels by more than the unrestricted measure. A second concern might be that there is a mechanical correlation between police killings and VAW if the police are targeting and killing women. We test for this possibility using police killings of women as an independent variable. Models 5-6 of Table C5 confirm that killings of women are uncorrelated with police-reported VAW, but they

predict higher reporting to DD and, thus, a wider reporting differential. Both of these tests substantiate our main findings and the trust mechanism (discussed in Section 7), which suggests that citizens update and increase their likelihood of calling DD after observing particularly heinous acts of police violence.

We then test the sensitivity of the dependent variables, beginning with police-reported VAW. We disaggregate the police-reported VAW variable by specific type of crime category in Table C6. The types of reported VAW that have more discretion in reporting, such as domestic violence, are more responsive to increases in police violence, consistent with our theory. Police-reported femicide, on the other hand, is positively and significantly correlated with police killings, consistent with the fact that femicides are typically discovered as deaths and less subject to underreporting.

Next, we construct alternative variables for VAW_{Diff} to capture propensity to report to one channel over the other. Our preferred variable, the raw reporting differential, is a difference in levels, which facilitates interpretation but is sensitive to changes in overall volume of reporting. We complement it with two other measures: the reporting rate and the relative share of reports to the police. Tables C7 details these measures and shows that all alternative outcomes reproduce the main results.

We then consider alternative model specifications, given that TWFE estimators are known to produce biased, and even negative weights on treatment effects when effects are heterogeneous across units or over time (Chaisemartin and D’Haultfoeulle 2020; Goodman-Bacon 2021). The standard correctives assume an absorbing treatment (Callaway and Sant’Anna 2021), but exposure to police violence is cumulative yet nonlinear process.¹⁸ Given the challenges to treatment assignment and pre-period definition, we treat exposure to police violence as a cumulative dose over time. We use the first twelve months of data to construct three precinct groups (low, medium, and high exposure to police violence), rather than selecting arbitrary police killings

18. Under a binary definition of exposure ($D_{it} = 1$ if precinct i records at least one police killing in month t), the median precinct that is ever exposed switches status 16 times over the 72-month window (Table C11), and the most-exposed precincts “switch” 30 times, with a police killing occurring in 47% of months. No precinct is ever permanently treated and, of the 97 precincts that experience at least police killing, 11 out of 97 experience no pre-period and all return to zero at some point.

as onset dates. We estimate an event study and report the details in Appendix C.2, including event study plots in Figure C1. For all three outcomes, the predictions are similar to the main results.

A final set of checks addresses the possibility that other factors, observed and unobserved, influence VAW reporting. First, though not the main focus of this paper, existing studies suggest that Rio de Janeiro’s organized criminal groups have been observed arbitrating VAW for residents, discouraging residents from calling the police in their communities, or both (Arias 2006, 2017; Barnes 2025). Using data from Trudeau (2024), we consider whether organized criminal group presence alters reporting patterns for the subset of precincts within the city. Table C9 shows that all coefficients mirror the main findings, but the signs for the VAW_{DD} and VAW_{Diff} are not statistically distinguishable from zero, likely because restricting the sample to the city represents a 70% decrease in sample size. While this allows for the possibility that criminal groups are somewhat engaged in the arbitration of VAW in their territories, these results suggest that their presence does not override the broader dynamics between citizens and the police.

Second, it is possible that there are time-varying within-precinct-level differences in awareness of DD, or knowledge of how to use it. For example, certain marginalized or isolated precincts may not have been aware of DD until it reached their social networks. To absorb such precinct-level heterogeneity, we construct a variable (ϕ_{it}) that calculates the multivariate distance (the unobserved “reporting gap”) between reported crimes to the police and to DD, using crimes that appear in both datasets. We construct three versions: $\phi_{Violent}$, $\phi_{Property}$, and ϕ_{All} , detailed in Appendix B. We control for each type of gap in Table C8, which supports the main findings, suggesting that they are not driven by unobserved time-variant heterogeneity in use or knowledge of either channel.

These results show that police violence is strongly associated with the reporting behavior our theory predicts, and are persistent when accounting for criminal group presence, awareness of DD, or when testing the sensitivity of the model and both

dependent and independent variables. One potential limitation in the generalizability of these findings is the unique role that *Disque Denúncia* plays in Brazilian society as an intermediary to law enforcement. How does police violence affect VAW reporting when an intermediary is weaker, or doesn't exist? The next section considers this question.

6 VAW Reporting as Intermediaries Weaken

Our TWFE results illustrate our theory of how police violence redirects reporting from the police to intermediary channels. In the absence of such intermediaries, however, we would still expect police violence to discourage VAW reporting to the police, for all the reasons related to the safety heuristic outlined in our theory. This section exploits a shock to the availability of DD in Rio de Janeiro to test the plausibility of our theory when an intermediary channel weakens.

After several budgetary shortfalls, DD was forced to scale back their operations in May 2016.¹⁹ Their call center quietly ceased 24-hour operations, no longer accepting calls between 11pm and 6am. Although callers had the option to leave a voicemail, a vast majority did not. This change in operating hours was implemented uniformly across the state, but was not publicized, likely because the DD leadership hoped funding would soon be restored. Figure D1 plots the calls to DD by hour over time, confirming that there is an abrupt discontinuity in call volume between the hours of 11pm and 6am in May 2016.

We leverage this exogenous change in DD operating hours to estimate its effect on VAW reporting. We estimate the following interrupted time series, indexing over t days and i precincts:

$$VAW_{it} = \beta_1 Shock_t + f(days_t) + \lambda_d + \pi_i + u_{it} \quad (2)$$

where VAW_{it} represents our three outcomes of interest. We also examine other

19. As an independent organization, DD depends on federal grants and philanthropic donations to survive.

Table 4: DD Night-time Closure on Reporting Volume

	<i>Disque Denúncia</i> Reports				Police Reports	
	VAW (1)	All (2)	Drugs (3)	Weapons (4)	VAW (5)	VAW (night) (6)
Shock	−0.059*** (0.013)	−0.229 (0.161)	−0.046 (0.047)	−0.018 (0.034)	0.086** (0.039)	0.029** (0.012)
Days (linear)	0.000 (0.000)	0.020*** (0.005)	0.004*** (0.001)	0.003*** (0.001)	−0.005*** (0.001)	−0.001*** (0.000)
Num. Obs	8357	8357	8357	8357	8357	8357
DV Mean	0.083	2.511	0.521	0.380	0.505	0.075
R ²	0.132	0.570	0.510	0.496	0.307	0.094
Precinct FE	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Weekday FE	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓

Note: Models use a 30-day bandwidth and models time trends in days using a linear polynomial function. The outcome VAW (night) refers to reports to the police between 11pm and 6am. Standard errors are clustered at the precinct-level: 137 clusters. * $p < 0.1$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$

DD reports as outcomes to benchmark the effect of the closure on VAW reporting. β_1 is the coefficient of interest, and the indicator $Shock_t$ takes a value of 1 on the day DD ceased 24-hour operations (May 15, 2016) and every day after. The main specification uses a 30-day bandwidth on either side of the shock, and the function $f(days_t)$ models time trends for the running variable using a linear polynomial function, though we include models with quadratic and cubic in the appendix. We include day-of-week (λ_d) and precinct (π_i) fixed effects and cluster standard errors at the precinct level.

Table 4 presents the main results. Model 1 shows that VAW calls to DD plummeted after 24-hour operations ceased. In the 30 days before the closure, DD received on average 0.107 VAW reports per precinct-day. Model 1 predicts, on average, a decline of 0.059 reports per precinct-day, a 55 percentage point reduction relative to baseline reporting. Across the entire state, this corresponds to approximately 242 missing reports during the 30-day period. We interpret this finding as suggestive evidence that callers neither left a message nor waited until the hotline re-opened to try again.

The reduction in operating hours particularly weakened DD’s ability to receive VAW reports, which is known to happen at night (United Nations 2015). Model 2 suggests that their total call volume slightly declined, but this effect size is not statistically distinguishable from zero. Models 3 and 4 shows that DD calls about drug trafficking and illicit firearm possession, the two most common topics, also experienced a minor yet imperceptible decline in call volume. Unlike VAW, reports to DD about these two categories are just as likely to occur during the day as night. These patterns suggest that the change in operating hours was particularly salient for callers reporting VAW compared with other disturbances.

When an intermediary becomes less reliable, does this re-incentivize direct reporting to the police? Partially, but many stay silent. Columns 5 and 6 show that there was a modest increase in VAW reports to the police following the shock to DD’s operating hours, concentrated in the nighttime hours (an increase by roughly 38 percentage points). Our back-of-the envelope calculations suggest that there were approximately 119 additional VAW reports to the police across the state during the 30-day period, which does not offset half of the “missing” reports to DD. The remainder seemingly went unreported.

The precincts suffering from acute police violence are driving these effects. Table 5 restricts the sample to precincts with the highest levels of police violence. Model 1 shows that VAW-related calls to DD experience a sharp and statistically significant decline, despite there being no significant change in aggregate call volume to DD or calls about drug trafficking, or illicit firearm possession (Models 2-4). Roughly 80 (33%) “missing” reports of VAW come from the 22 precincts with high exposure to police violence, and the estimated post-shock decline of 0.120 reports per precinct-day corresponds to a 63% reduction relative to baseline, greater in magnitude than that of the entire sample. These results tell us that VAW reports from precincts most exposed to police violence comprise a disproportionately high share of VAW reports to DD, and thus, were most affected by the reduction in operating hours.

Unlike the main findings reported in Table 4, callers exposed to high levels of

Table 5: DD Night-time Closure on Reporting Volume, Violent Precincts

	<i>Disque Denúncia</i> Reports				Police Reports	
	VAW (1)	All (2)	Drugs (3)	Weapons (4)	VAW (5)	VAW (night) (6)
Shock	−0.120*** (0.041)	−0.911 (0.738)	−0.167 (0.212)	−0.141 (0.150)	0.254 (0.165)	0.031 (0.038)
Days (linear)	0.001 (0.001)	0.074*** (0.020)	0.012** (0.004)	0.012*** (0.004)	−0.011** (0.005)	−0.001 (0.001)
Num. Obs	1342	1342	1342	1342	1342	1342
DV Mean	0.190	7.732	1.849	1.425	0.926	0.124
R ²	0.115	0.533	0.498	0.483	0.265	0.089
Precinct FE	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Weekday FE	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓

Note: Sample includes the top 25% precincts with the highest average level of police killings during the 2013-2016 pre-period. Models use a 30-day bandwidth and models time trends in days using a linear polynomial function. The outcome VAW (night) refers to reports to the police between 11pm and 6am. Standard errors are clustered at the precinct-level: 22 clusters.

* $p < 0.1$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$

police violence did not reengage with the police to report VAW after the restriction of DD’s operating hours. The coefficients in Models 5 and 6 are positive yet imprecisely estimated, suggesting that the “missing” reports to DD went unreported to the police as well. We interpret these findings as supporting evidence that, for callers exposed to police violence, reporting to an intermediary is preferable to reporting to the police, but as intermediaries grow less reliable, many callers will prefer to stay silent rather than make claims directly to a predatory police force.

We conduct several tests to ensure the robustness of these findings, beginning with quadratic and cubic model specifications in Table D1. respectively. Both specifications support the main findings that the bulk of “lost” calls are unreported to the police.

Figure D2 then shows that these conclusions are robust to flexible bandwidths. We re-estimate Equation 2 at every symmetric bandwidth from 1 to 45 days for the linear, quadratic, and cubic specifications. The estimated decline in VAW calls to DD

is negative at nearly every bandwidth of a week or more and statistically significant at the 5% level in 30 of the 39 bandwidths under the linear specification. Similar to the main results, the estimated increase in nighttime VAW reports to the police never approaches the magnitude required to offset the missing calls to DD. Table D2 reports estimates at the algorithmically-defined optimal bandwidths derived from Calonico et al. (2014). Every point estimate retains the sign of the main findings. The increase in police-recorded VAW remains statistically significant, while the decline in VAW calls to DD do not, which is unsurprising given that this outcome draws the narrowest window of the six.

These results add to the main findings by showing that when DD becomes a less available intermediary, individuals—especially those exposed to police violence—are more likely to stay silent than report VAW to the police.

7 Mechanisms

Our theory argues that citizens use police killings in their neighborhood as a heuristic to determine whether filing a police report is worth the risk of direct engagement with the police. In this section, we argue that citizen trust in the police is the primary mechanism through which these heuristics form. We contrast trust in the police with an alternative mechanism about institutional capacity, both of which are derived from existing literature.

7.1 Trust in the Police

We draw from Slough and Torreblanca’s (2025) conceptualization of trust in the police as one that is *cognitive* and *relational*: it is a set of beliefs about how police agents will treat them or respond to their report, which can be updated based on observations of police conduct. When police kill someone “like them,” we expect individuals to negatively update their beliefs about the trustworthiness of police to receive and properly handle a crime they report. Further, we expect this updating to be most acute for

individuals who reside in close geographic proximity and are otherwise similar to the victim, increasing the sense of shared identity.²⁰

To establish the localized relationship between police killings and trust, we draw from the Latinobarómetro 2023 survey. Table 6 shows that respondents who identify police violence as the “most frequent source of local insecurity” report substantially lower trust in the police, and the association strengthens monotonically as we move from the cross-national aggregate to the city of Rio de Janeiro. In Latin America as a whole, identifying police violence as the main local problem is associated with a 0.36-point drop in trust on a four-point scale, whereas within the city of Rio de Janeiro, trust declines nearly a full point. The strength of this association in the city is consistent with other public opinion data. A 2018 survey found that 70% of Rio residents feared being harmed by the police, and a staggering 92% feared being wounded or killed by stray bullets in their own neighborhoods (Fórum Brasileiro de Segurança Pública 2018).

The trust mechanism operates at the individual level. Our qualitative data shows that respondents cited localized police violence as a driver of their reluctance to report to the police, grounding their assessments in what they personally witnessed or experienced in their communities. One of our interview respondents described her neighborhood’s relationship with law enforcement in stark terms: “The police only come here to mistreat us (*maltratar*) and beat us. Why would I want them here?” (Interview 6).

We also expect police violence to amplify any domain-specific concerns about reporting VAW to the police. The extant literature has identified three such concerns. First, survivors or their allies are concerned that they will be minimized or ridiculed when they come forward (Ricciardelli et al. 2021), including being dismissed in the absence of physical evidence (Murphy-Oikonen, Chambers, et al. 2022; Higa et al. 2008).

20. Although police violence is geographically bounded, trust is not, and a police killing may affect trust in the police outside of the precinct where it occurred. Drawing from theories of linked fate (Dawson 1995), this allows for police killings to modestly affect the baseline level of trust in police across all precincts, but not to the same degree as those who feel closest to the victims.

Table 6: Trust in Police and Perceived Police Violence

	Latin America (1)	Brazil (2)	Sudeste (3)	RJ State (4)	RJ Metro (5)	RJ City (6)
Police Violence						
= Local Problem	−0.357*** (0.018)	−0.481*** (0.076)	−0.722*** (0.118)	−0.810*** (0.236)	−0.869*** (0.288)	−0.934* (0.467)
Intercept	2.191*** (0.038)	2.666*** (0.116)	3.088*** (0.187)	2.731*** (0.406)	2.895*** (0.453)	2.779*** (0.618)
Num.Obs.	18 567	1161	499	94	66	35
DV Mean	2.277	2.572	2.543	2.064	2.015	2.057
R2	0.132	0.051	0.090	0.148	0.178	0.195
R2 Adj.	0.131	0.048	0.082	0.109	0.125	0.088
Country FE	✓					
Demographic controls	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓

Note: DV: Trust in police (1 = No trust, 4 = A lot of trust). IV: Binary indicator if respondent identifies state violence/police abuse as the most frequent type of local violence. Source: *Latinobarometer 2023*. * $p < 0.1$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$

Second, they are concerned about being personally victimized after coming forward, including gendered or intersectional discrimination (Córdova and Kras 2020; Murphy-Oikonen, McQueen, et al. 2022) and physical victimization, including harassment or abuse by officers (Jassal 2020). Third, a response to a VAW claim that is *too* aggressive could create opportunities for retaliation by the perpetrator or their allies, otherwise compounding the danger the survivor faces.

Our qualitative evidence illustrates how police violence can inflame these extant concerns. One VAW survivor was dismissed by the police after reporting domestic violence. They claimed that “she would go back to him anyways” (Interview 6). Another survivor said, “Unfortunately I was a victim of sexual violence, and at the police station no one helped me. On the contrary, they humiliated me” (Interview 8). In both cases, there was latent fear and mistrust in the police before they even arrived at the station.

An important question for our theory is whether citizens trust intermediaries (such

as DD) when their trust in the police is low. Our qualitative evidence suggests that police violence does not reduce trust in DD to the same extent. One military police officer in Rio de Janeiro emphasized the importance of intermediaries, stating, “Sometimes women are not ready to report... or sometimes they will never be able to come to the police, but these alternative resources [like DD] are crucial for them to receive some kind of support.” (Interview 7).

7.2 Alternative Mechanism: Police Institutional Capacity

An alternative mechanism linking police violence to VAW reporting patterns centers on police institutional capacity, largely through the expansion of women’s police stations and centers. If women’s police stations effectively expand capacity to process VAW, then in precincts where such stations exist, we would not expect alternative channels like DD to be as useful. We test the plausibility of this mechanism by examining whether the presence of a women’s police station (DEAM, *Delegacia Especializada de Atendimento à Mulher*) in a precinct moderates the relationship between police violence and VAW reporting.

At a high level, DEAMs appear to have had a positive effect in Brazil. FBSP (2025) reports that, conditional on deciding to report VAW to the police, survivors are 40% more likely to report to a DEAM than to a regular station, and several studies provide evidence that they have contributed to a decrease in VAW (Córdova and Kras 2020; Perova and Reynolds 2017; Santos et al. 2019).

We re-estimate Equation 1 and report the results in Table C10. We reconstruct the VAW_{Police} variable by only counting those that were reported at a DEAM, and reconstruct the VAW_{Diff} variable using only DEAM-reported incidents. We find that police violence is not associated with as strong of a decline in VAW reports to DEAMs (Model 1) as in the main findings, but the sign is still negative, suggesting that police violence is still negatively associated with reporting VAW to the police, even at a DEAM. Police violence remains a significant and positive predictor of VAW reports to DD and of redirected reporting from DEAMs to DD. The shift in reporting is slightly

smaller in magnitude than in the primary findings, allowing for the possibility that DEAMs attenuate the predicted shift. We interpret these results as suggesting that police institutional capacity is insufficient to offset the adverse effects of police violence.

8 Conclusion

Underreporting of VAW to authorities is common, and often attributed to the complex relationships between survivors and the perpetrators or to negative potential encounters with frontline officers. We argue that police violence discourages VAW reporting to the police, theorizing that citizens use it as a heuristic about how they will be treated upon reporting VAW and, upon observing police violence, lose trust that the police will adequately process their VAW claim. We further argue that police violence pushes citizens to report VAW to intermediaries to the police that they evaluate as safer, such as anonymous tiplines. We offer empirical evidence that police violence is associated with (1) decreased VAW reports to the police, (2) increased VAW reports to an intermediary tipline, and (3) relatively more VAW reports to the tipline vis-à-vis the police. This paper also demonstrates that, absent an accessible intermediary, citizens largely prefer to not report rather than report directly to the police. We provide qualitative and survey evidence suggesting that trust in the police is the mechanism driving these findings.

Despite their ubiquity across the Global South, VAW and police violence are rarely studied together, likely because one often happens in private while the other often occurs on the streets. Rio de Janeiro provides an ideal context for examining the two. Often, the neighborhoods with high police violence experience overlapping vulnerabilities—poverty, weak state presence, and pervasive criminal governance—creating heightened barriers to accessing formal justice mechanisms. This challenge extends beyond Rio de Janeiro, Brazil, and even Latin America. Across the Global South, marginalized communities experience overlapping forms of state violence and exclusion, and the barriers to VAW reporting are often embedded within these political

and institutional contexts.

The relationship between police predation and claim-making to the police is complex. Past studies show how police violence can lead to physical or material harm (Blair and Morse 2021; González 2020; Magaloni and Rodriguez 2020; Magaloni, Franco-Vivanco, et al. 2020) or rupture trust between police and the population (R. Blair et al. 2025; Bruin et al. 2025; Cruz 2009; Flores-Macías and Zarkin 2022; Tiscornia 2019). We add to a nascent literature that connects predatory policing with citizenship (González and Mayka 2023; Magaloni, Robles, et al. 2020; Lerman and Weaver 2014), demonstrating how police predation distorts governance provision. Future work—similar to studies of procedural unfairness when reporting VAW and trust in VAW legislation (Rabello Kras 2024a, 2024b)—should examine the conditions under which survivors of VAW regain trust in the police and other state providers of governance.

This paper sheds light on the “dark figure of crime” by differentiating underlying VAW incidence from reported incidence to two sources, both theoretically and empirically. By comparing police-reported and intermediary-reported VAW, we demonstrate that police violence can frustrate the state’s efforts to measure and process VAW. This suggests a likely mismatch between the available public safety resources and what the public requires. Future research should further examine the selection mechanisms driving VAW reporting to a range of state and non-state channels, including health, social, and community organizations. A clearer picture of the tradeoffs of reporting to one versus another will help policymakers understand the obstacles to reporting and deliver resources to the appropriate actors.

Our findings emphasize that efforts to increase VAW reporting cannot be divorced from broader reforms of public security, adding to the growing chorus that gendered violence *is* political violence (Lake and Hartman 2025; Wood 2018). Building trust in the state requires not only increased policing capacity, but also a broader effort to curb police violence, more broadly. While the main theoretical contribution of this paper is to demonstrate the relationship between police violence and VAW reporting, a secondary finding is that intermediating channels are most used by citizens in conditions

of compound exposure to police *and* societal violence. High police violence discourages citizens to report to the police, but high civilian violence exacerbates these obstacles. In the absence of such public security reforms, citizens will continue to view the state as a source of danger or neglect rather than protection, with profound consequences for both justice and public safety.

More broadly, the findings speak to enduring debates in political science about how violence and predation shape citizen-state interactions. When law enforcement perpetrates violence, citizens may disengage from direct engagement with the state, not only in politics, but also in their most intimate claims for protection.

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Supporting Information

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A Main variables: additional descriptions and figures

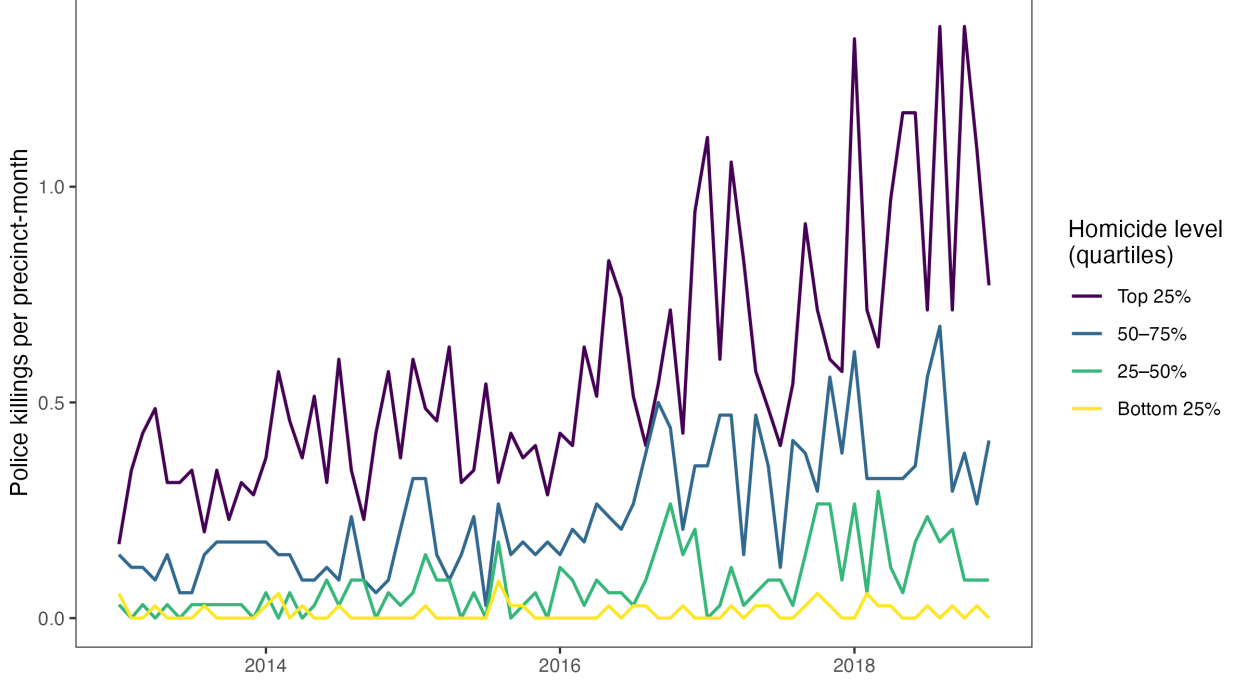
A.1 Precinct vignettes: VAW reporting time series

These vignettes correspond to the time series in Figure 1, showing police and DD reporting in Precincts 5 and 22.

- On the left (Precinct 5) is a precinct with relatively low levels of VAW and where reports to the police outpace reports to DD for the entire time series. This precinct represents the central business district and one of the main nightlife (bars, nightclubs) zones of the capital city. Though people do reside here, it is primarily an area where people pass through, both day and night. That people call the police to report VAW at consistently higher levels than they call DD in such an area makes sense, given that acts of violence might be more likely to occur on the street or in a commercial establishment rather than in the home or a residential area.
- The right panel of Figure 1 shows a precinct (Precinct 22) with higher levels of VAW. DD registered more reports of VAW than the police beginning in 2017, driven by a slight decrease in calls to the police and a more noticeable increase in calls to DD. This coincides with a deteriorating relationship between the police and favela residents in Complexo do Alemão, which is policed by the 22nd precinct. Journalists report that at the beginning of 2017, police began “taking over residents’ houses” and terrorizing residents as they waged war with trafficking groups (Inzunza and Pardo 2018). While we do not know how the unobserved incidence of VAW changed in this setting, calling the police in such a precinct became more of a taboo, and residents seeking help may have wanted the shield of anonymity.

A.2 Additional figures

Figure A1: Police killings per precinct-month, by homicide quartiles



Note: We group precincts by quartile for average police-reported homicide level for the entire time series (2013-2018). The four lines shown in this time series correspond to within-group average levels of monthly police killings.

B Control variable: reporting gap

Section 5.2 notes that we calculate the reporting gap between the police and *Disque Denúncia* and include it as a control variable in an alternative specification. We combine precinct-month-level data from both sources for all crime types that appear in both datasets (that are not VAW or police killings). We estimate the Mahalanobis distance between Police and DD reports for matched non-VAW crime categories within each precinct-month:

$$\phi = D(X_i, X_j) = \sqrt{(X_i - X_j)S^{-1}(X_i - X_j)}$$

This metric is rescaled in multivariate standard deviations, so crimes of varying frequencies are rendered comparable. A larger value of ϕ indicates greater systematic underreporting (e.g., more reporting to DD relative to the police). We calculate three different measures of the reporting gap, given that different types of crimes are more or less subject to different kinds of bias in reporting:

1. $\phi_{Violent}$: this is computed over extortion, attempted homicide, armed robbery, threat, and physical injury;
2. $\phi_{Property}$: this is computed over robbery and theft from pedestrians, residences, businesses, automobiles, and cargo;
3. ϕ_{All} : this is computed over both violent and property crime types.

In the models reported in Section 5.2 (shown in Table C8), all gap variables enter the equation with a one-period lag (ϕ_{t-1}) to avoid post-treatment bias, since police violence mechanically reduces crime counts and could otherwise compress the gap contemporaneously.

C Robustness checks: TWFE models

Section C.1 re-estimates Equation 1 using alternative independent and dependent variables, additional control variables, and a test against an alternative mechanism. Section C.2 uses an event study as an alternative specification.

C.1 Alternative TWFE models

Table C1: Police Violence and VAW Reporting, contemporaneous

	VAW (Police)		VAW (DD)		VAW (Diff)	
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)
Police Violence	−0.597*** (0.158)	−0.598*** (0.155)	0.845** (0.260)	0.850** (0.261)	−1.443*** (0.359)	−1.449*** (0.359)
Homicide (Count)		0.004 (0.084)		−0.041 (0.058)		0.046 (0.110)
Num.Obs.	9914	9914	9914	9914	9914	9914
DV Mean	15.433	15.433	2.968	2.968	12.465	12.465
R2	0.884	0.884	0.561	0.561	0.737	0.737
R2 Adj.	0.882	0.882	0.551	0.551	0.731	0.731

Note: Independent variables are contemporaneous (current-month) police violence and homicide counts. Models include precinct- and month-year-fixed effects. Standard errors are clustered at the precinct-level: 138 clusters. * $p < 0.1$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$

Table C2: Police Violence and VAW Reporting, lagged police violence and homicide

	VAW (Police)		VAW (DD)		VAW (Diff)	
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)
Police Violence (Lag t-1)	-0.582*** (0.171)	-0.583*** (0.169)	0.676*** (0.174)	0.683*** (0.176)	-1.259*** (0.284)	-1.266*** (0.287)
Homicide (Lag t-1)		0.006 (0.091)		-0.051 (0.058)		0.056 (0.120)
Num.Obs.	9776	9776	9776	9776	9776	9776
DV Mean	15.401	15.401	2.999	2.999	12.403	12.403
R2	0.885	0.885	0.561	0.561	0.735	0.735
R2 Adj.	0.882	0.882	0.551	0.552	0.729	0.729

Note: Police Violence and Homicide are both monthly counts, lagged by one month. Models include precinct- and month-year-fixed effects. Standard errors are clustered at the precinct-level: 138 clusters. * p < 0.1, ** p < 0.05, *** p < 0.01

Table C3: Police Violence and VAW Reporting, lagged homicide

	VAW (Police)		VAW (DD)		VAW (Diff)	
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)
Police Violence	-0.597*** (0.158)	-0.601*** (0.151)	0.845** (0.260)	0.841** (0.263)	-1.443*** (0.359)	-1.442*** (0.358)
Homicide (Lag t-1)		0.006 (0.091)		-0.053 (0.059)		0.060 (0.119)
Num.Obs.	9914	9776	9914	9776	9914	9776
DV Mean	15.433	15.401	2.968	2.999	12.465	12.403
R2	0.884	0.885	0.561	0.563	0.737	0.736
R2 Adj.	0.882	0.882	0.551	0.553	0.731	0.730

Note: Police Violence is a contemporaneous count and Homicide is a monthly count, lagged by one month. Models include precinct- and month-year-fixed effects. Standard errors are clustered at the precinct-level: 138 clusters. * p < 0.1, ** p < 0.05, *** p < 0.01

Table C4: Police Violence and VAW Reporting, lagged police violence and homicide by two

	VAW (Police)		VAW (DD)		VAW (Diff)	
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)
Police Violence (Lag t-1)	-0.582*** (0.171)	-0.549** (0.167)	0.676*** (0.174)	0.676*** (0.175)	-1.259*** (0.284)	-1.225*** (0.279)
Homicide (Lag t-2)		-0.037 (0.060)		-0.066 (0.057)		0.028 (0.094)
Num.Obs.	9776	9638	9776	9638	9776	9638
DV Mean	15.401	15.319	2.999	3.030	12.403	12.289
R2	0.885	0.885	0.561	0.562	0.735	0.733
R2 Adj.	0.882	0.883	0.551	0.553	0.729	0.727

Note: Police Violence is a monthly count, lagged by one month, and homicide is a monthly count, lagged by two months. Models include precinct- and month-year-fixed effects. Standard errors are clustered at the precinct-level: 138 clusters. * p < 0.1, ** p < 0.05, *** p < 0.01

Table C5: Police Violence and VAW Reporting, alternative measures of police violence

VAW Outcome:	Police	DD	Diff	Police	DD	Diff
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)
Police Violence (massacre)	-1.595* (0.784)	3.018* (1.282)	-4.613*** (1.369)			
Police Violence (killings of women)				0.036 (2.703)	9.476* (3.834)	-9.440* (4.702)
Homicide	-0.055 (0.163)	-0.093 (0.127)	0.038 (0.233)	-0.058 (0.162)	-0.089 (0.127)	0.031 (0.230)
Num.Obs.	9638	9638	9638	9638	9638	9638
DV Mean	15.319	3.030	12.289	15.319	3.030	12.289
Mean IV	0.017	0.017	0.017	0.003	0.003	0.003
R2	0.885	0.562	0.733	0.885	0.562	0.732
R2 Adj.	0.882	0.553	0.727	0.882	0.552	0.726

Note: Police Violence variables and Homicide are three-month moving averages (current month and the two preceding). Columns (1)–(3) restrict the police violence count to killings recorded on a precinct-day with two or more deaths (165 of the 2300 killings in the sample); columns (4)–(6) restrict it to killings whose victim was a woman (30 killings, in 19 precincts). Models include precinct- and month-year-fixed effects. Standard errors are clustered at the precinct-level: 138 clusters. + p < 0.1, * p < 0.05, ** p < 0.01, *** p < 0.001

Table C6: Police Violence and VAW Reporting, by VAW subtype

	DV (1)	LMDP (2)	DV + LMDP (3)	Femicide (4)	Threats (5)
Police Violence	−0.223 (0.143)	−1.224** (0.377)	−1.447*** (0.348)	0.044** (0.015)	−1.026** (0.360)
Homicide	−0.022 (0.055)	−0.006 (0.176)	−0.028 (0.159)	0.001 (0.003)	0.017 (0.106)
Num.Obs.	9638	9638	9638	9638	9638
DV Mean	0.217	15.046	15.262	0.057	9.903
R2	0.245	0.872	0.885	0.132	0.807
R2 Adj.	0.229	0.869	0.882	0.113	0.803

Note: Each outcome is a count of police reports per precinct-month, and each column re-estimates Equation 1 on that outcome. Column (1) is bodily injury (*lesão corporal*) recorded as domestic or family violence against a female victim but not filed under the *Lei Maria da Penha* national domestic violence law; column (2) is bodily injury filed under the *Lei Maria da Penha*; column (3) sums the two, giving all domestic-violence injury reports. Column (4) is femicide, including attempts, which make up 397 of the 546 reports in the sample. Column (5) is criminal threat (*ameaça*) filed under the *Lei Maria da Penha*. Columns (1), (2) and (4) are the three components of the VAW (Police) measure used in the main models. Models include precinct- and month-year-fixed effects. Standard errors are clustered at the precinct-level: 138 clusters. + $p < 0.1$, * $p < 0.05$, ** $p < 0.01$, *** $p < 0.001$

Table C7: Police Violence and VAW Reporting, alternative dependent variables

	Rate per 100,000			DD Share
	VAW (Police)	VAW (DD)	VAW (Diff)	
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)
Police Violence	−0.378*	0.287	−0.665**	0.019***
	(0.176)	(0.200)	(0.250)	(0.005)
Homicide	−0.138*	−0.053	−0.085	0.002*
	(0.057)	(0.035)	(0.068)	(0.001)
Num.Obs.	9638	9638	9638	9353
DV Mean	13.613	2.185	11.428	0.128
R2	0.384	0.338	0.257	0.548
R2 Adj.	0.370	0.323	0.241	0.537

Note: Columns (1)–(3) express each outcome as a rate per 100,000 residents to hold constant the fact that precincts differ in population. DD Share in Column (4) ($DD/(DD + Police)$) removes the scale entirely, but is undefined in the 285 precinct-months with no VAW report to either channel and has the commensurate decrease in sample size. Models include precinct- and month-year-fixed effects. Standard errors are clustered at the precinct-level: 138 clusters. * $p < 0.1$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$

Table C8: Police Violence and VAW Reporting, with reporting gap

VAW Outcome:	Police (1)	DD (2)	Diff (3)	Police (4)	DD (5)	Diff (6)	Police (7)	DD (8)	Diff (9)
Police Violence	-1.413*** (0.350)	1.973*** (0.536)	-3.386*** (0.740)	-1.297*** (0.371)	1.831** (0.547)	-3.129*** (0.775)	-1.382*** (0.357)	1.949*** (0.543)	-3.331*** (0.758)
$\phi_{Violent}$	0.187+ (0.111)	-0.210 (0.141)	0.397+ (0.231)						
$\phi_{Property}$				-0.489* (0.224)	0.598** (0.186)	-1.087** (0.397)			
ϕ_{All}							-0.150 (0.126)	0.113 (0.151)	-0.263 (0.265)
Num.Obs.	9638	9638	9638	9638	9638	9638	9638	9638	9638
DV Mean	15.319	3.030	12.289	15.319	3.030	12.289	15.319	3.030	12.289
R2	0.886	0.570	0.738	0.887	0.578	0.743	0.886	0.570	0.738
R2 Adj.	0.883	0.561	0.732	0.884	0.568	0.737	0.883	0.560	0.732

Note: Each model controls for a single reporting gap measure, entered with a one-period lag (ϕ_{t-1}); see Section B for variable construction. Models do not control for homicide and include precinct- and month-year fixed effects. Standard errors are clustered at the precinct-level: 138 clusters. + $p < 0.1$, * $p < 0.05$, ** $p < 0.01$, *** $p < 0.001$

Table C9: Police Violence and VAW Reporting, controlling for criminal group presence

	VAW (Police)		VAW (DD)		VAW (Diff)	
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)
Police Violence	−0.958*	−0.927*	0.334	0.322	−1.292	−1.249
	(0.393)	(0.398)	(0.854)	(0.860)	(1.169)	(1.172)
Homicide	−0.343+	−0.375+	0.007	0.031	−0.350	−0.406
	(0.185)	(0.198)	(0.443)	(0.402)	(0.526)	(0.496)
Drug faction present		2.480		−4.271		6.750+
		(2.110)		(3.358)		(3.384)
<i>Milícia</i> present		0.977		−0.332		1.309
		(0.788)		(2.253)		(2.466)
Contested territory		1.155		0.175		0.980
		(0.705)		(0.624)		(0.844)
Num.Obs.	2859	2859	2859	2859	2859	2859
DV Mean	19.112	19.112	4.699	4.699	14.412	14.412
R2	0.902	0.903	0.603	0.609	0.749	0.753
R2 Adj.	0.898	0.899	0.587	0.593	0.739	0.743

Note: Sample size is restricted to the 41 precincts of the municipality of Rio de Janeiro. Monthly criminal presence data at the favela level, from [Trudeau \(2024\)](#), is aggregated to the police-precinct level, and three indicator variables are constructed if (a) a drug faction is present in the precinct-month, (b) a *milícia* group, and/or (c) a turf war. Odd columns estimate Equation 1 on the sample of precincts just in the capital city; even columns add the criminal presence controls. Models include precinct- and month-year-fixed effects. Standard errors are clustered at the precinct-level: 41 clusters. + $p < 0.1$, * $p < 0.05$, ** $p < 0.01$, *** $p < 0.001$

Table C10: Police Violence and VAW Reporting, Women’s Police Stations

	VAW (DEAM)	VAW (DD)	VAW (Diff)
	(1)	(2)	(3)
Police Violence	−0.167 (0.335)	1.871*** (0.543)	−2.038*** (0.740)
Homicide	0.192 (0.201)	−0.138 (0.129)	0.113 (0.226)
Num.Obs.	8938	8938	8938
DV Mean	8.436	3.238	12.833
R2	0.891	0.577	0.738
R2 Adj.	0.889	0.567	0.732

Note: **VAW (DEAM)** in Column (1) is the 3-month moving average of the number of police-reported VAW per precinct-month that is reported at a women’s police station. **VAW (Diff)** in Column (3) calculates the difference between **VAW (DEAM)** and the main 3-month moving average outcome for VAW reported to *Disque Denúncia*, reported in Column (2). Models include precinct- and month-year-fixed effects. Standard errors are clustered at the precinct-level: 128 clusters. + p < 0.1, * p < 0.05, ** p < 0.01, *** p < 0.001

C.2 Police killings event study

Two-way fixed-effects estimators of the kind in Equation 1 average treatment effects with weights that can be negative when effects vary across units or over time, which means the estimated coefficient need not be a convex combination of the underlying effects (Chaisemartin and D’Haultfoeulle 2020; Goodman-Bacon 2021). The estimators developed to address this (Callaway and Sant’Anna 2021) are built for absorbing treatments with a well-defined onset. Our treatment does not have that structure. Table C11 reports how often the binary exposure indicator changes status. Of 138 precincts, 41 never record a police killing between 2013 and 2018 and none recorded a killing in every month. Among the 97 precincts that are ever exposed, the mean number of “switches” (moving from a month with a police killing to one without, or vice versa) is 16.9 and the median is 16; in the quantile of precincts with the most police killings, there are, on average, 29.5 “switches” during the 71 months in the time series, or 47% of months. These precincts are not units that enter a treated state and stay there. They are precincts that are highly exposed to police killings, which does not happen every single month. This is why we prefer a dose-based design that takes cumulative exposure into account.

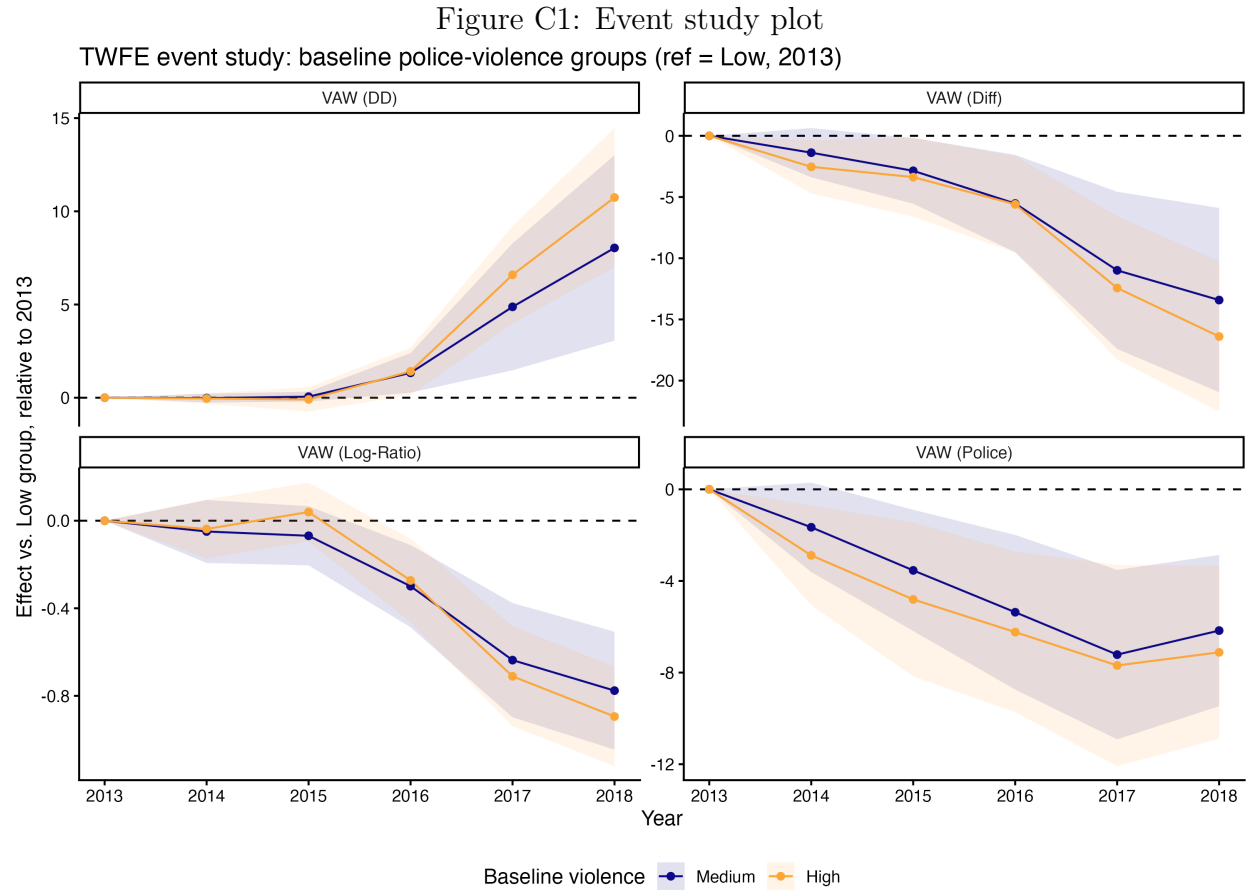
Table C11: Treatment switching in the binary police-killing indicator, 2013–2018

Sample	Precincts	Switches			Exposure	
		Mean	Median	Max	Months (mean)	Months (%)
All precincts	138	11.9	6.5	39	11.2	0.157
At least one switch	97	16.9	16.0	39	16.0	0.223
Medium exposure	28	16.5	18.5	33	13.5	0.188
High exposure	26	29.5	30.0	39	33.8	0.470

Note: $D_{it} = 1$ if precinct i records at least one police killing in month t . A switch is any month-to-month change in D_{it} in either direction, so the maximum possible over 72 months is 71. Baseline groups are defined on 2013 police killings, as in Figure C1.

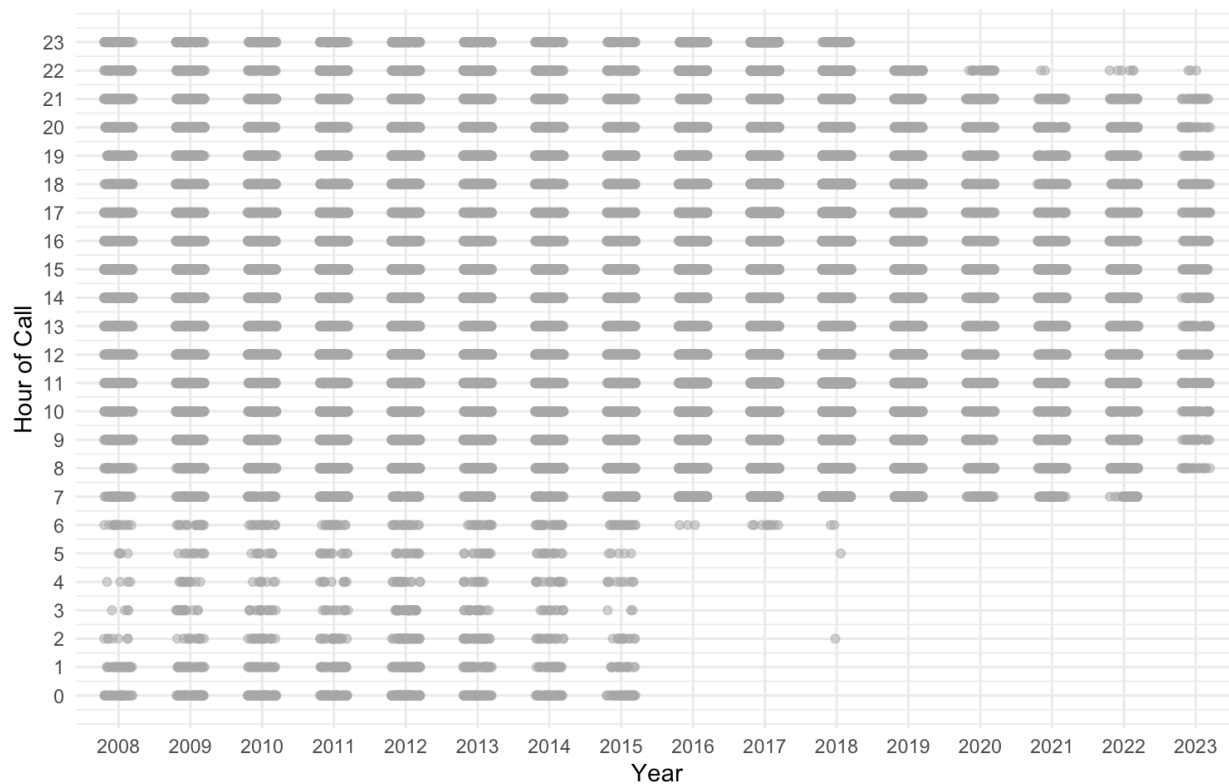
We classify precincts by police-violence intensity during the 12 months in 2013, the first year of the panel, into Low (no killings, $n = 84$), Medium (at or below the median of 2 killings among exposed precincts, $n = 28$) and High ($n = 26$) groups, and interact these fixed groups with year indicators, taking Low as the reference group and considering 2013 the pre-period. The grouping is a meaningful dose measure: over 2014–2018 the three groups average 0.077, 0.267 and 0.810 killings per precinct-month respectively. Because group membership is fixed at baseline, no precinct changes comparison group over the window and the forbidden comparisons that generate negative weights do not arise. Figure C1 plots the results. The trends are ordered by dose and grow over time. Relative to Low-intensity precincts and to 2013, police-recorded VAW in High-intensity precincts falls by 2.883 reports by 2014 and by 7.116 by 2018, with Medium-intensity precincts tracking the same path at consistently smaller magnitudes (-1.656) and -6.166. Reports to DD reports move in the opposite direction and with a delay: the 2014 and 2015 coefficients are indistinguishable from zero, after

which they rise sharply to 1.689 in 2016, 7.163 in 2017 and 11.395 in 2018 for the High group. The reporting differential increases over time, from -2.731 in 2014 to -17.527 in 2018. We interpret the fact that the police-reported VAW declines more abruptly than the DD-reported VAW as evidence that citizens quickly withdraw from the police upon repeated exposure to police violence, and turn towards DD to report VAW more gradually.



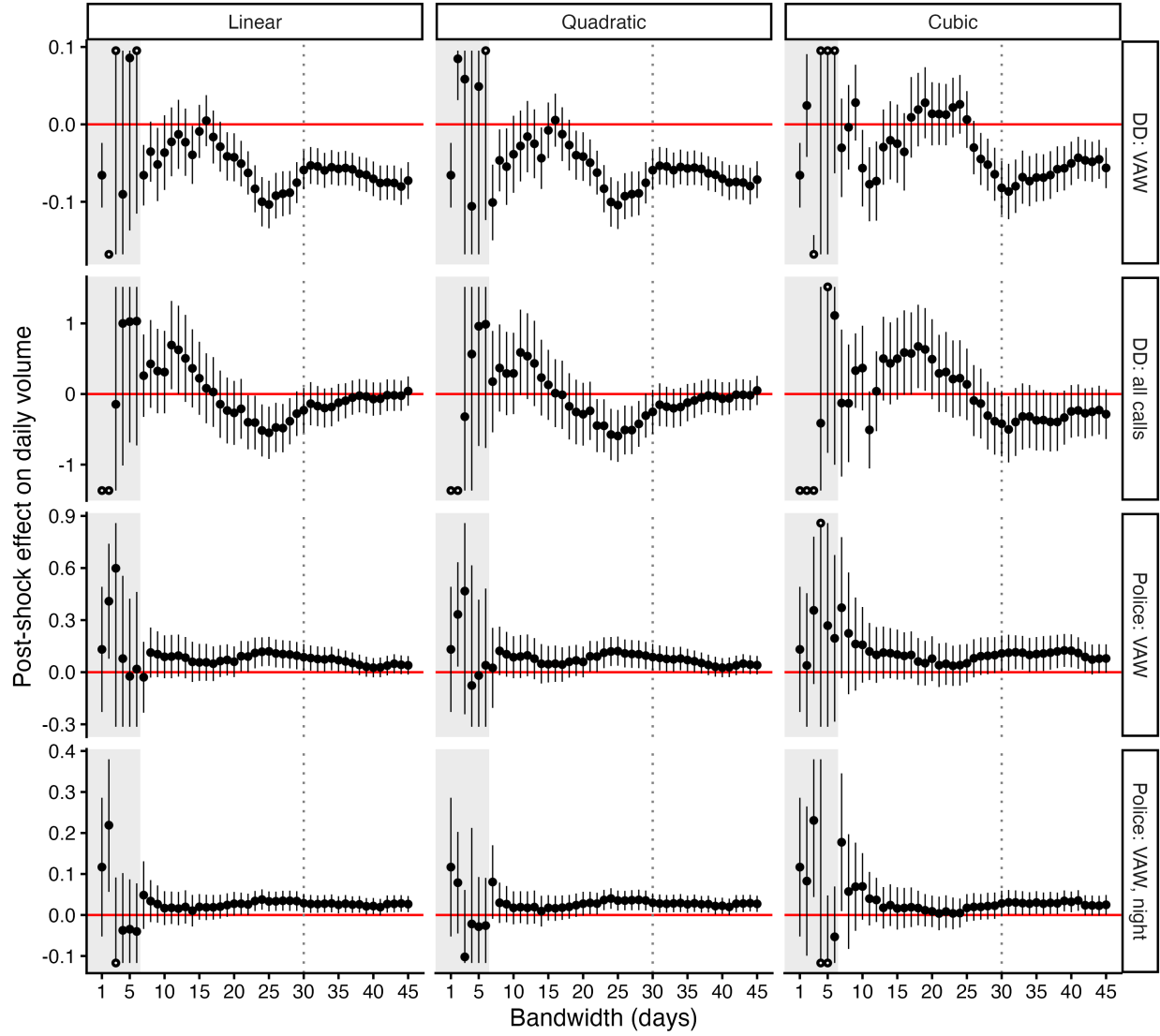
D Robustness checks: Interrupted time series

Figure D1: VAW calls to *Disque Denúncia*, pre- and post-shock
Call Hours by Year (VAW)



Note: Y-axis shows hours of the day, on a 24-hour scale. X-axis shows year-months. The hotline closed overnight in May 2016, between the hours of 11pm (23:00) and 6am.

Figure D2: ITS bandwidth sensitivity: linear, quadratic, and cubic specifications



Note: Post-shock coefficient from Equation 2 estimated at every symmetric bandwidth from 1 to 45 days, with 95% confidence intervals clustered by precinct. The dotted line marks the ± 30 -day window used in the main tables. In the shaded region (< 7 days) the day-of-week fixed effects are not identified.

Table D1: DD night-time closure on reporting volume, quadratic and cubic functions

	<i>Disque Denúncia</i> Reports				Police Reports	
	VAW	All	Drugs	Weapons	VAW	VAW (night)
Panel A. Quadratic Specification						
Post-shock	−0.059*** (0.013)	−0.253 (0.159)	−0.051 (0.047)	−0.021 (0.033)	0.087* (0.039)	0.030* (0.012)
Days	0.000 (0.000)	0.021*** (0.005)	0.004*** (0.001)	0.003** (0.001)	−0.005*** (0.001)	−0.001** (0.000)
Days ²	0.000 (0.000)	−0.001*** (0.000)	0.000** (0.000)	0.000+ (0.000)	0.000 (0.000)	0.000+ (0.000)
Num. Obs	8357	8357	8357	8357	8357	8357
DV Mean	0.083	2.511	0.521	0.380	0.505	0.075
Precint FE	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Weekday FE	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Panel B. Cubic Specification						
Post-shock	−0.082*** (0.018)	−0.421+ (0.236)	−0.068 (0.065)	−0.036 (0.050)	0.108* (0.052)	0.028+ (0.016)
Days	0.002* (0.001)	0.033** (0.012)	0.005+ (0.003)	0.004 (0.003)	−0.006* (0.003)	−0.001 (0.001)
Days ²	0.000 (0.000)	−0.001*** (0.000)	0.000** (0.000)	0.000+ (0.000)	0.000 (0.000)	0.000+ (0.000)
Days ³	0.000* (0.000)	0.000 (0.000)	0.000 (0.000)	0.000 (0.000)	0.000 (0.000)	0.000 (0.000)
Num. Obs	8357	8357	8357	8357	8357	8357
DV Mean	0.083	2.511	0.521	0.380	0.505	0.075
Precint FE	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Weekday FE	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓

Note: Models use a 30-day bandwidth and models time trends in days using a quadratic (Panel A) and cubic (Panel B) polynomial function. The outcome VAW (night) refers to reports to the police between 11pm and 6am. Standard errors are clustered at the precinct-level: 137 clusters.

+ p < 0.1, * p < 0.05, ** p < 0.01, *** p < 0.001

Table D2: DD night-time closure on reporting volume, optimal bandwidth

	<i>Disque Denúncia Reports</i>				<i>Police Reports</i>	
	VAW	All	Drugs	Weapons	VAW	VAW (night)
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)
Post-shock	-0.036 (0.025)	0.626+ (0.319)	0.165+ (0.098)	0.113 (0.074)	0.090* (0.045)	0.016 (0.021)
Bandwidth (days)	10	12	12	13	22	12
Observations	2877	3425	3425	3699	6165	3425
DV Mean	0.085	2.784	0.582	0.417	0.505	0.068
Precint FE	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Weekday FE	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓

Note: Models use a linear polynomial function to model time trends. The outcome VAW (night) refers to reports to the police between 11pm and 6am. Bandwidths are selected separately for each outcome by the MSE-optimal procedure of from Calonico et al. (2014), which is why the number of observations differs across columns. Each column is a symmetric window of the reported bandwidth around the May 15, 2016 closure. Standard errors are clustered at the precinct-level: 137 clusters. + $p < 0.1$, * $p < 0.05$, ** $p < 0.01$, *** $p < 0.001$

E Fieldwork ethics and qualitative data

The authors confirm that the human subjects research pursued complies with the Principles and Guidance for Human Subjects Research. The human subjects evidence presented in this paper includes the semi-structured interviews with public officials, including police officers and service providers, community leaders, social workers, and favela residents. The study is approved by the [author’s institution] Committee for the Protection of Human Subjects [protocol number redacted for anonymity]) and by the local ethics committee at Fundação Getúlio Vargas in Brazil.

Interviews. All interviews were conducted in person by the authors, or by enumerators trained by the authors, in Brazilian Portuguese. Verbal consent was sought and obtained before the interview began, and there was no deception involved. To further protect confidentiality, interviews were not audio recorded, the authors took written notes. All identities are anonymized, and translated text is lightly edited for clarity. Respondents were informed of this and were reminded that they did not have to answer all questions. List of cited interviews:

- Interview 1: Favela resident, São Paulo, November 2025.
- Interview 2: Specialized public prosecutor, São Paulo, July 2025.
- Interview 3: Tipline worker, Rio de Janeiro, April 2026.
- Interview 4: Women’s shelter employee, São Paulo, June 2025.
- Interview 5: Tipline worker, Rio de Janeiro, March 2026.
- Interview 6: Favela resident, São Paulo, December 2024.
- Interview 7: Military police officer, Rio de Janeiro, September 2025.
- Interview 8: Favela resident, Rio de Janeiro, May 2026.